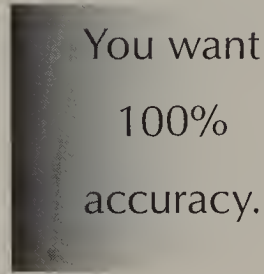


only difference being the middle initial. I was in line behind a man at the airport last week who was being delayed at passport control because of a similar situation. He even shared the same middle name, not just the initial, as this other person. My gentleman knew the other man's name, address, and details, even his hair color, because he has run into problems for the last several years, due to having the same name as some other guy. I imagine there are many John Smiths out there, but don't be so sure that no one else has your name, even if you do have an uncommon name. Or maybe you are John Smith Sr., and John Smith Jr. has lousy credit. You want to be sure only your information is showing on your report.



Verification in Progress...

So take a red pen, grab a cup of coffee, and have a seat. Today is the day you review your credit report. Verify that your social security number is correct. Confirm every detail of your personal information. Then look at all the rest.

As you go down the form, line by line, make sure that loans and debts listed are actually yours. If you find a twenty dollar bill on the street that isn't yours, great. If you find items on your credit report that are not yours, not good at all.

If there are any judgments on the credit report, verify that they are indeed against you. You should know if you have had a judgment against you. Check for closed accounts. Maybe you had a car lease that was closed three years ago and it still shows as an open account. Perhaps there is a credit card listed, and you know that you never had a Diner's Club card. These are the types of things to be on the lookout for.

If you find an error reported by a creditor, contact that creditor directly. If they do not give you the time of day to attempt to resolve your issue, or even pretend to care, you can contact the credit reporting agency. Each of the three credit bureaus has ways to submit your dispute online, which you may recall seeing when you were on their websites, getting your credit report.